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3.2 The Tide Turns

Sometimes a new leader brings new energy and ideas to a situation and makes all the difference. That's just what happened when a new commander was brought in to lead the southern troops.

MAIN IDEA A change in leadership and a victory in the Carolinas helped change the course of the war in the Southern Colonies.

A NEW GENERAL

The tide of the war in the Southern Colonies began to turn in 1780. That's when General **Nathanael Greene** replaced Horatio Gates as commander of the Continental Army's southern troops. As a Quaker, Greene should have been a **pacifist**, or a person who stood against war and violence. So when Greene expressed his desire to organize troops against the British, the Quakers expelled him. After serving with Washington and leading troops in New York, New Jersey, and Pennsylvania, Greene was sent to the Southern Colonies to try to change the direction of the war for the Americans.

Greene's strategy involved increasing the Continental Army's mobility and agility. Spread out over the Southern Colonies, the large British Army had trouble moving quickly and changing plans. Greene used smaller forces to draw British troops away from strategic locations. He also benefited from a growing southern dislike of the British, whose troops and supporters had destroyed local houses and farms, executed prisoners of war, and made false promises of protection. Greene impressed southern colonists, including Loyalists, by protecting their property and enforcing order. Growing numbers in the Southern Colonies joined Greene's army or guerrilla forces.

PATRIOTS AND LOYALISTS CLASH

While the Americans changed their strategy, the British did not. British strategy in the Southern Colonies depended heavily on Loyalist support. The British relied on pitting American Loyalists and Patriots against each other, with little British troop involvement. That strategy failed at the **Battle of Kings Mountain**.

In the fall of 1780, Lord Cornwallis headed north from South Carolina, believing the time had come for British forces to conquer all the Southern Colonies. His troops met with heavy resistance. At Kings Mountain, near the border between the Carolinas, 2,000 Patriots, fighting independently from the Continental Army, clashed with an enemy force made up almost entirely of other Americans. These frontier Patriots dealt a resounding defeat to 1,100 Loyalist soldiers fighting under Major Patrick Ferguson, the only British Army member at the battle. Patriot fighters put to death some Loyalists who surrendered, perhaps as revenge for recent British executions of American prisoners.

The Battle of Kings Mountain was the first of many victories for the Patriots in the Southern Colonies. Loyalists sustained big losses at Cowpens in South Carolina, and Cornwallis and his troops suffered casualties at Guildford Court House in North Carolina. As a result, Cornwallis headed back toward Virginia. Because of the importance of the Battle of Kings Mountain, Thomas Jefferson called it "the turn of the tide of success."

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Nathanael Greene's leadership affect the war in the Southern Colonies?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Why might frontiersmen have fought the Battle of Kings Mountain?
3. **SUMMARIZE** Why did Cornwallis's plan to control the Southern Colonies by enlisting the aid of Loyalists fail?

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